



BEFORE

People used symbols to keep records long before the invention of true writing.

TALLY BONES

The **earliest** form of note-taking known in the Middle East, the **tally bone** dates back 30,000 years. The bones **recorded lunar months**, which governed the ritual cycles observed by **hunter-gatherers** << 30–31.

CLAY TOKENS

From 9000 to 3000 BCE, people in the Middle East used **clay tokens** to record commercial transactions, sealing them into **clay envelopes** called **bullae**. A token's **shape** symbolized either **goods** (animals, grain) or specific **large numbers**. The example above is from **Uruk** << 44–45 and is dated to 3700–3200 BCE.



CLAY TOKENS AND BULLA

STAMP AND CYLINDER SEALS

A **seal** << 54–55 was a detailed engraved image identifying the **sender** of a message. The seal was pressed on wet clay by stamping, or rolling in the case of cylinder seals. Such seals appeared millennia before the development of writing.

HOW WE KNOW

THE ROSETTA STONE

Hieroglyphs were deciphered in 1822–24 by French Egyptologist and linguist Jean François Champollion. He used the Rosetta Stone—a stele of Ptolemy V bearing the same inscription in three scripts: hieroglyphic Egyptian (top), demotic Egyptian (middle), and Greek (bottom). He deciphered the Egyptian scripts by comparing identifiable words, such as names, in all three scripts, allowing him to work out the sound of each Egyptian sign from the Greek.

ROSETTA STONE



According to ancient tradition, writing was either invented by an individual or handed down to humanity by the gods. The Sumerian poem *Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta* describes how King Enmerkar invented writing instantly to record a message too complicated for his messengers to memorize. We now know, however, that the development of writing was a gradual process, taking centuries. Our

knowledge depends on surviving examples of ancient writing. Degradable materials, such as papyrus, bamboo, and parchment, have not endured, so the earliest surviving inscriptions tend to be found on monuments. These texts, such as the hieroglyphs on Egyptian tombs, are too sophisticated to be the first use of writing. In Mesopotamia (see p.54–55), however, people wrote on durable clay tablets that survive in

CUNEIFORM A writing technique widely used in the Middle East between 2500–330 BCE. Scribes used symbols made with wedge-shaped impressions pressed into clay or carved into stone. Many languages and civilizations used cuneiform, from Sumerian to Persian.

huge numbers, so the progression of their earliest writing can be traced. At early stages, writing was made up of

The Writing on the Wall

Writing—the symbolic representation of spoken language—and its development represents a massive step forward in the intellectual evolution of humans. The development of writing occurred independently in five different areas: Mesopotamia, Egypt, India, China, and Mesoamerica.

Message from a temple

This clay tablet was written in a temple of Mesopotamia in 3100–2900 BCE. The script is a kind of proto-cuneiform—an early, pictorial stage in Mesopotamian writing development. The tablet probably describes grain either distributed by or offered to a temple. Thousands of tablets such as this have been unearthed at Uruk in Mesopotamia (see pp.54–55). They recorded transactions and contracts made by the temples.

The **barley symbol** is very common in ancient Mesopotamian writing. Barley was one of the most important commodities and was used to make bread and beer—the two staples of the Mesopotamian diet.

Drawn symbols were used in proto-cuneiform. Drawing was a messy and time-consuming process compared to impressing standardized wedge signs, as was done later by cuneiform scribes.

A **box of symbols** represented one transaction or sentence. Writers of proto-cuneiform grouped signs in boxes, not lines or columns.

A **seal impression** acted as a signature. People involved in contracts authenticated them by pressing their seal into the clay, rather than writing their names. In this case, the seal image represents a hunting dog.

The **walking (transport) symbol** suggests the items specified elsewhere on the tablet were moved. The absence of verbs makes it impossible to say whether the transport was to or from the temple in which the tablet was found.

A **transaction tablet** was usually sized to fit into the palm of the scribe's hand, although much larger cuneiform tablets do exist.

